

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

The Grateful Life ~ Tell About It

23 November 2025



"Fields" by Wilhelm Morgner

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

Childcare & Children's Programming at First Church

FCCLA offers childcare and children's programming during service for all ages — from infants through youth. For more information or to register your child, please stop by the First Kids First check-in table in the entrance to the Cathedral, or follow the signs in the hallway through the middle doors of the Sanctuary.

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions...

We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Improvisation on ST. GEORGE'S WINDSOR and NUN DANKET

Meditation on Kyrie from *Missa Orbis Factor* / Toccata Deo Gratias (Richard Keys Biggs)

Two Dakota Native Airs:

- La Framboise
- Renville

Meditation on "I Am The Earth" (Birgid Täht and Marii Valjataga) and "Grateful To Be" (arr. D. Harris)

Three pieces by Saginaw Rozzo:

- Close Path and Improvisation
- Hymn to the Great Creator and Improvisation
- Lilac Fugue

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Michael Lehman

Words of Gathering

Rev. Lehman & Rev. Lisa Domke

Through hardship and trials against all the odds,
we are beginning to trust that the world
can be a brave place for us,
and we have been called to walk here,
in this place and time.

We have made ancestors of our instincts,
intuitions, and dreaming;
we have allowed love into where it
had never before been received;
we have grown life where once
it was barren.

Our gifts, and our goodness given,
are blessings for us all.
With just a few found and trustworthy seeds,
together we are nurturing the greatest harvest
there is: a life of belonging for all of us,
and for all who are yet to come.

On this day, with thankful hearts,
let our gratitude flow like rivers,
as we give thanks for this life,
we have been given, to share!

May it forever be so.
May it forever be so for all of us!

Please stand as you are able, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

Come, O Thankful People, Come

ST. GEORGE'S WINDSOR

Come, O thankful people, come, raise the song of harvest home;
All is safely gathered in as the winter storms begin;
God our Maker does provide for our wants to be supplied;
Come to God's own temple, come, raise the song of harvest home.

All the blessings of the field, all the stores the gardens yield,
All the fruits in full supply, ripened 'neath the summer sky,
All that spring with bounteous hand scatters o'er the smiling land,
All that liberal autumn pours from its rich o'erflowing stores.

These to you, our God we owe, source from whom all blessings flow;
And for these our songs we raise, grateful vows and solemn praise.
Come, then, thankful people, come, raise the song of harvest home;
Come to God's own temple, come, raise the song of harvest home.

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Lehman

Holy One,
everywhere we turn, everyplace we look,
in each intake of breath
and in every word exhaled,
may we dwell in possibility.

What we see, what we hear,
what we taste and smell and touch -
let all these realities intermingle
with the mystery of what will be.
Help us, O God, to move towards that which
is most precious to us, and through
our connectedness,
let us be transformed as we are
being woven once again,
into your likeness.

*In your endless flow,
let us become your life here on earth.
We pray this with our gratitude
for the One who taught us the way.
Amen and Amen!*

***Introit**

"Even So, Lord, Quickly Come"
Cathedral Choir

ASHI DAY

***The Lord's Prayer**

Rev. Domke

*Great Spirit, our Creator, who is in all places,
Sacred is your name.
May your wisdom guide us,
Your will be done in our lives, as it is throughout Creation.*

*Provide for us today the nourishment we need,
And forgive us our wrongs, as we forgive those who have wronged us.*

*Lead us on the path of understanding and respect,
And protect us from ignorance and harm.*

*For you are the source of all power, beauty, and love,
From generation to generation, forever and always. Amen.*

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Lehman

It is in community that we are best challenged
to live out the ideals we set before ourselves.
Whether framed by sages, prophets, or poets,
the ideals we choose reflect
not who we believe ourselves to be,
but who we know we might become.

In community, may those who gather with us
reflect to us the truth about who we are,
that we might be about the task
of growing into who we might become.

And may we each, in our human frailty,
be a gift and mirror to each other.

This morning in this sacred place we call home,
may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Reading from Our Religious Tradition *from Psalm 147*

Rev. Domke

For the Word of God in Scripture,
for the Word of God in Nature,
for the Word of God among and within us.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Lehman

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

For the wisdom you reveal to us,
For the truth you show to us,
For the way you came to us,
Became one of us, yet so much more than us:
We are so grateful.

For the expanding grandeur of Creation,
Worlds known and unknown,
Galaxies beyond galaxies,
Filling us with awe and challenging our imaginations:
We are so grateful.

For this fragile planet earth,
Its times and tides, its sunsets and seasons:
We are so grateful.

For the joy of human life,
Its wonders and surprises, its hopes and achievements:
We are so grateful.

For this community,
Our common past and future hope,
Our oneness transcending all separation,
Our capacity to work for peace and justice in the midst of
apathy:
We are so grateful.

For high hopes and noble causes,
For faith without fanaticism,
For understanding of views not shared:
We are so grateful.

For all who have labored and suffered for a fairer world,
Who have lived so that others might live in dignity
and freedom:
We are so grateful.

May we live not imprisoned by our fears,
but released by your hope;
may we live not by our words or by our deeds,
but by your truth which is too vast to hold;
may we live not on the level of understanding
or in our own wisdom,
but by the power of the life we co-create with you.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

Meditation Anthem

“Meditation”
Cathedral Ringers, Grace Sheldon-Williams, *Director*

SAGINAW ROZZO

Sermon

The Grateful Life ~ Tell About It

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

The Eucharist and Blessings

Prayer of Blessing

*Thanks be to you, O God,
for your presence and your purpose,
for loving kindness and your steadfast Spirit.
May the blessings of this table
strengthen our faith, increase our generosity,
and unify our hearts,
for we pray this in the name
the One who shows us the way.*

*We give you thanks for this meal - and for each other.
Amen & Amen.*

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Domke

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

“Let All Things Now Living”
Cathedral Choir, Fahad Siadat, *Assistant Director*

KATHRINE K. DAVIS

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Prayer of Offering**

Rev. Domke

Holy Giver of Life and Love,
you fill our world with so many abundant gifts
that we struggle to know how to show our gratitude.
We thank you for the gift of life and breath,
for hearts that see more truly than eyes,
for ears that hear song even in silence,
for the bread of your life that sustains us
even when our bodies hunger.

We give thanks for an offer of friendship
when we expected only anger.
We give thanks for acceptance
where we expected only closed doors.

We give thanks for the compassion of others,
and for the melting of our hearts.

And we pray now that these offerings will be used
to share these life giving gifts with all your children.
[Bankson & Sokolove]

May it ever be so.
Amen.

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Fregin

When we thought what we were doing was unimportant,
we were Setting the Table and preparing the food,
we were touching hurting hearts and bodies,
we were opening doors for curious minds
as we helped each other discover truth in ways that invited fresh awareness,
and continues to prepare the way for the transformation of our lives.

*The Holy One has spread a table before us...
and we give thanks that they are opening our hearts and hands
as we embody their compassion, their inclusiveness, and their generosity.*

Together we celebrate this day, as those who long to follow
the Way of the One who shows us the Way.

May it be so.

Choral Response

“Nun danket alle Gott”
Cathedral Choir

J.S. BACH

***Hymn for the Journey**

Now Thank We All Our God

NUN DANKET

Now thank we all our God with heart and hands and voices,
Who wondrous things has done, in whom the world rejoices,
Who, from our parents’ arms, has blessed us on our way
With countless gifts of love, and still is ours today.

O may this bounteous God through all our life be near us,
With ever joyful hearts and blessed peace to cheer us,
And keep us still in grace, and guide us when perplexed,
And free us from all ills in this world and the next.

All praise and thanks to God our Maker now be given,
To Christ, and Spirit too, our help in highest heaven,
The one eternal God, whom earth and heaven adore,
For thus it was, is now, and shall be ever more.

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence
Lilac Fugue - Reprise (Saginaw Rozzo)

Inside The Music

“Saginaw has been a member of our choir and bell choir for several years now. We have enjoyed his compositions for organ, and for choir, but this is his first piece for bell choir. We are so fortunate to be a place where we regularly hear music premieres. To be witness to the birth of new music has a unique power all its own, like a bud pushing up through the earth. Our bell choir, under Grace’s leadership, has now premiered three pieces. Saginaw’s “Meditation” feels particularly suited for this season of gratitude. The music contains an intoxicating blend of searching and settledness that brings interesting definition to gratitude. As we give thanks, we both recognize with wonder the benefits that flow through our lives. That encourages a heart opening that leads to a sense of expansive fullness as if our spirits want to connect to everything at once. That expansiveness brings stillness. The melody features a regular off beat pattern that lends the music its searching quality. The frequent use of octaves idiomatic to bell playing gives it a gravity that aligns with expansiveness. A delightful use of the raised fourth near the end of the piece sounds like the kind of smile we get when we feel connected to everything around us. It is a meditation on gratitude meaningfully aligned with this week. Saginaw has Native American heritage through his father, and has been exploring his ancestral identity since I’ve known him. He has put in time to connect to different Indigenous communities in L.A., learning as he builds relationships. I have been inspired by his process and his openness to discovery. As Native American Heritage Month nears its end, to have celebrated the importance of Indigenous peoples in this nation by listening to their words and music is important. To build relationships and learn to listen deeply to the leaders from vast Indigenous heritage represents a different level of connection. We all have so much to

be grateful for, and so much to learn. I am grateful for people like Saginaw who remind me the importance of connection and gratitude through his actions and music." -*Dr. David Harris*

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